gardens and buildings' – Qutubuddin Khan swapped his tutor's duties with Mir Muhammad Khan.[66]

Mir Muhammad, who had led the Mughal forces to Kabul, was Shamsuddin Ataka's elder brother, and it might have been that he gave Hakim the affection, protection and loyalty his brother had lavished on Akbar. But what have might-have-beens to do with history? Mir Muhammad was loyal to the family, but he was also known for his 'impetuosity and roughness' – one night, incensed, he stormed out of Kabul, leaving the child-king in his realm and to his fate.[67]

According to Abul Fazl, this was because Hakim lacked 'inborn goodness . . . sound reason, and . . . honest and loyal servants'. He might also have added, the young ruler of Kabul was barely ten years old – and a great temptation to ambitious and unscrupulous men. One of these had appeared on the scene – Khwaja Hasan Naqshbandi – and contrived, somehow, to have Hakim marry him to his sister, the very same princess who was lately widowed (and thankfully rid) of Abul Ma'ali. It was the fact that the marriage was arranged without his counsel and consent that sent Mir Muhammad into a rage, and back to Punjab.

Two years later, in 1566, Akbar was back from his bout against the Uzbeks and recuperating in Nagarchain once again – this time experimenting with firelit balls that allowed for games of night polo[68] – when fresh news of his brother's unhappy adventures arrived. Sulaiman and Haram had made another – their fourth! – bid on Kabul; Hakim had fled across the Indus, and needed Akbar's help again.[69]

Akbar had already dispatched a man called Faridun – a courtier and also Hakim's uncle – to advise his brother and keep him safe from malevolent influence. Now, he sent a messenger – the aptly titled Khushkhabar Khan, lord of good tidings – with money, a robe of honour, a horse from Akbar's own stables, all for Hakim, along with instructions for the ataka khail to set out for Kabul a second time.

The two men arrived within a few days of each other, and while Khushkhabar Khan brought no disgrace to his name, Uncle Faridun revealed himself 'a regular leprous spot'.[70] Having been entrusted with keeping 'seditious men' from 'speaking to the [prince]', Faridun went and proposed a brash sedition of his own. Let Hakim take Lahore! There was